

Institutional design and the stability of collective deterrence

Torgeir Aambø

Norwegian Defence Research Establishment (FFI)

Abstract

Collective deterrence for a coalition of states depends on two key principles: the institutional design of decision-making, formalized as a social choice function that aggregates states individual levels of resolve, and the coalitions available escalation technology. In this paper we study the interactions of these principles via a multi actor signalling game, with a focus on understanding and eliminating weak-link equilibria. This model provides a simple formal framework for understanding how small alliances, such as the Nordic countries, which we use as an example, can maintain credible deterrence without external guarantees.

1 Introduction

2 Theory

3 Conclusion